

Main

Report Name (Org_Country_Year_Report Type)

ILRI_Kenya_2022-23_3-month report

Fellowship Organization

International Livestock Research Institute (ILRI)

Fellowship City

Nairobi

Fellowship Country

Kenya

Fellowship Start Date

08/22/2022

Anticipated Fellowship End Date

08/21/2023

What is your fellowship title/role?

Communications Specialist

What are your primary responsibilities?

- Working with the CKM team to write blogs, articles and media releases
- Support development of multimedia products such as videos, podcasts and other digital media
- Work with social media team to develop engaging social media around events, campaigns or new releases
- Support work of media and public awareness including developing a contact mailing list of journalists, e-letter and other media monitoring system
- Work with rangelands program leader to develop and implement communication strategy

I receive adequate direction and support to perform my fellowship responsibilities.

Disagree

Did you receive any sort of orientation, handover or onboarding when you started your fellowship?

Somewhat

Please describe your orientation/onboarding and note who handled it.

I didn't have a strong on-boarding program. There doesn't really seem to be a protocol around how to onboard the PiAf fellows. Although we had several meetings leading up to our arrival in Nairobi, once we got on the ground we didn't have much of an orientation in terms of job responsibilities and communications protocol. I have mostly been learning as I go. Even 3 months in, I don't feel fully onboarded and am still sorting out items that should have been done earlier on, such as having printer access.

If you did not receive any kind of orientation, what information or guidance were you provided at the start of your fellowship?
Describe a representative day at work.

I arrive at 9 and spend most of my morning working on current projects. I like to do deep work in the morning so that is when I tend to write blogs or podcast scripts. I eat lunch around 12:30 then go on a quick walk. The afternoons tend to be more collaborative with meetings. I also do smaller tasks in the afternoon like social media posts and tracking ILRI's presence in the media. I typically leave work at 5pm.

On average, how many hours per week do you work?

40

How would you describe your effectiveness in your fellowship post so far?

Neutral

Please briefly describe 1-2 specific projects that you have undertaken or accomplishments you have made so far.

1. I covered the inaugural youth in pastoralism consultation that brought together young people working in pastoralism from East Africa to discuss the field in the face of climate change. The event was capstoned with the creation of a statement addressing the needs and opportunities of pastoralism for climate resilience. I got to attend the last day of the event and meet the participants. I wrote articles for the CGIAR on the event, as well as a separate article on individual pastoralist profiles. One participant was also selected to attend COP27 and present at an official side event. For this, I wrote a separate profile article of her and also covered the event at COP27 and wrote an article for it.
2. I produced a podcast on the drought in the Horn of Africa and the need for earlier action. I did this through the lens of a partner organization working to better link early warning systems with the institutions that respond. I conducted interviews with officials and researched the drought effects as well as produced the script and helped with production.

What is your organization's work culture like?
What is your office environment like? Please comment on the size and structure of the office(s) where you do most of your work.

I work in the communications and knowledge management office on campus, which is basically the campus library. My desk is in an open space surrounded by books. My team is about 10 people, many of whom are much older than I am and are also international (not from Kenya). The campus itself is very large and hosts satellite campuses of other CGIAR organizations. There are also labs and a research farm as well as a gym, pool, and residences on property.

To whom do you report?

Awareness and Advocacy Specialist (main supervisor, oversees projects and provides feedback)

Communications and Knowledge Management Head (create blogs and other writing support on policy matter)

Communications and Outreach Team Leader (work with her on pastoralism blogs and writing support)

Have you had an initial check-in with your supervisor to set up a work plan and to set goals for your work during your fellowship year?

No

Was this meeting helpful in understanding your role and setting goals for your fellowship year?

Please explain why you have not met with your supervisor and if you have plans to do so going forward.

We check-in weekly about my current and upcoming projects but we never had a conversation about my goals for work. This is something I plan to broach after the holidays are over. It was not something

Please briefly indicate 3-5 professional goals you have for the rest of your fellowship year. Your professional goals should align with your work plan.

1. Continue to meet with and learn from individuals working in the international development field. I am keen to understand the breadth of the field and make connections along the way.
2. Work more on the policy side of ILRI, especially covering events and providing support to projects that directly link to promoting research to policymakers.
3. Continue to reach out to scientists at ILRI and the satellite campuses to understand more of the research being conducted and further my ability to work on projects.
4. Work to streamline the communications teams project management system. Currently, there isn't a centralized system to track work plans and I am eager to spearhead and pilot a new system.

How often do you check in with your supervisor?

Weekly

Have you had an opportunity to travel for work so far?

Yes

Describe this travel opportunity. Include location(s) and a brief description of the purpose of the trip(s).

I have gotten to do numerous day trips.

1. To ILRI's research station for various events.
2. To Kisumu to record a podcast episode on vaccine uptake
3. To Makueni county to attend the last day of the pastoralist youth consultation.
4. To high-level meetings in Nairobi county

My supervisor has been really good about bringing me along to various events and opportunities. I feel really grateful to be included in these trips and look forward to traveling more throughout the fellowship year.

I feel adequately prepared for my position's professional responsibilities.

Disagree

Please briefly explain your response.

I do not have a background in communications or multimedia production and I have had to learn everything on the fly. I also don't fully understand the office politics of working at such a large organization and do not feel supported in navigating them. For example, I wrote a blog post for a science project as per the request of my supervisor only for it to be erased from the site after publication. This was my first blog post and I didn't know I had to rope in certain individuals for approval and was never told to do so by my supervisor. Although I am gaining a greater understanding of the office politics there are still instances where this happens.

Life at Fellowship Site

How did you travel to your host country and site? Please be specific

My flights were covered by ILRI and were booked through their travel agency. Because of this I had quite the convoluted flight path to Nairobi. I flew British Airways from Philadelphia to Boston, Boston to London, then London to Nairobi. The travel agency also covered the booking process and cost of the flight for my return ticket home. The total cost was \$1805.

What kind of visa/ permit do you have or applied for?

Student Pass

How did you obtain (or are obtaining) your visa or permit?

I had to apply for a police clearance/good conduct letter in my hometown, then applied online. ILRI is helping with the process.

Did you apply for and receive your visa / permit before heading to your host country or after arriving?

No, I still do not have it but am in the process of obtaining it.

What costs were associated with obtaining your visa or permit?

\$20 for the police good conduct letter, \$51 for tourist visa to enter the country, \$50 for a yearly student pass

Did you pay the visa / permit costs or were they covered by your organization?

ILRI is paying the student pass, I had to pay for everything else

Are you still having challenges obtaining your visa/ permit?

Yes

If yes, please explain further

There have been myriad communication issues with the internal ILRI team that handles visas. We had trouble contacting them at first and they never told us to get a letter of good conduct from our local police stations before arriving so that also caused issues. I have yet to hear back from the student pass issuing agency if my application has been approved though it is submitted. I have extended my tourist visa and hope that my student pass application will be approved before it runs out.

g) Do you have any suggestions to help future Fellows navigate the visa / permit application process?

Get in touch with ILRI early about the visa process and be your own advocate! It was really frustrating for me because I was not supported by my supervisor in this endeavor and had to navigate it on my own.

What vaccinations were you required to obtain prior to your departure? How much did your vaccinations cost? Did you get a yellow fever vaccination?

No vaccinations are required for Nairobi beyond the covid vaccine needed to initially get into the country. I plan to travel and have previously been to East Africa so I already had yellow fever and rabies. I did get a typhoid booster before I left. I made an appointment at Walgreens and it cost about \$80.

How was your arrival and first week in your host country? Any improvements that could streamline the assimilation process for future Fellows?

The arrival was easy. I arrived late at night and ILRI arranged transportation for me from the airport. They also provided housing on-campus for the first 3 nights which was really nice. The first week was hectic though because my co-fellow and I had to find housing. We didn't book anything in advance because of elections taking place and the possibility of our on-the-ground start date being pushed back. Definitely book housing in advance if you can. I would recommend just booking an Airbnb for one month so you can get a feel for the city before committing long-term.

Is housing provided by and/or paid for by your organization? Please explain.

No

Do you live in a location that is more urban or rural?

Very Urban

Please describe your living environment

I live on a busy street in an apartment complex.

How do you typically travel between your home and your work? How much does your daily transportation cost and how long is your commute?

I use Uber or Bolt, both ride-sharing apps. The average trip costs between \$5-\$9 and I typically split the trip with my co-fellow. The average time to commute is about 30 minutes as ILRI is quite a bit away from town.

If you live in a more rural area, what are the closest urban areas you can travel to for shopping, airport, larger medical centers, etc.?

N/A

How is the weather in your host country? What season are you presently in?

The weather is really nice in Nairobi. Since the city is at altitude, it never gets too hot and has a dry climate. It can get quite chilly so a sweater/jacket is necessary. It currently has been raining a lot.

What is the appropriate clothing for work and outside of work at your fellowship post and in your community in general?

Workwear is pretty casual. I usually wear jeans and a nice top or slacks and a tshirt. I do have more formal business wear for events and meetings though. Outside of work, Nairobi is very cosmopolitan and I wear what I usually wear in the U.S.

How have you been spending your free time?

I have been spending my free time in the typical way I would in the U.S. I hang out with friends and have gotten involved in a lot of activities. I horseback ride, attend cycle and dance classes, and hike on the weekend with hiking groups.

I've been able to successfully navigate my personal/social life both back at home and at my fellowship post.

Agree

Please briefly explain your response below.

I have been able to navigate my personal and social life both in Nairobi and at home. It has been fairly easy to make friends though I sometimes get overwhelmed with the amount of social activities I have. It has been a bit harder to stay in touch with friends and family back home especially with the time difference, but I have been intentional about staying in touch.

Would you say you live and work in a safe area?

I do feel safe at work and home. Both have 24 hour security and are gated so it is not a problem. I am able to walk around my part of town alone during the day as well.

What precautions do you take to ensure your safety?

I usually only walk around during the day and I always carry my phone with me.

What has been your experience with crime so far? (Please note that any security or safety concerns or incidents should be reported directly to PiAf staff per PiAf safety and security protocol.)

I haven't had any experience with crime so far.

Describe the incidence of crime and the general security situation within your city/town. Could you recommend specific areas future Fellows might consider for safe housing? What about areas that should be avoided?

Petty theft is common in Nairobi. I haven't experienced this yet but I always make sure my valuables are put away.

Safe housing is in Kilimani, Kileleshwa, Westlands, among the many. Just avoid the central business district for housing and only go there during the day.

Please refer back to the goals you set for yourself before orientation. Are you working towards these goals? Have you met any of them? Changed any of them? Please explain.

Yes I am working towards these goals. A big goal of mine was to gain a greater understanding of the international development field and refine my professional interests. Just the mere fact of being in Nairobi has been incredible in advancing this goal.

In my job though, I have had to reset my goals and expectations as the work environment is not what I expected it to be. I am still working through what I want out of my job this year and the goals I want set.

Do you have any frustrations with your living arrangements, your work or your life outside of work?

Outside work: the amount of traffic and how long it takes to get anywhere, having to constantly rely on a ride-share app to get around, no reliable public transportation or ride-share apps outside of the city

Work: feeling as if my work is insignificant, little support and mentorship from my supervisor, lack of passion and motivation for the work I am doing, lack of organization in my team, being constantly called the "intern", people getting me and my co-fellow confused because we have the same name, frustration surrounding the bureaucracy of such a large NGO and things taking an incredibly long time to be approved, not feeling like my work or efforts are appreciated, not enjoying the type of work I am doing

Has there been anything that you have needed but have not been able to locate or acquire?

No

How have you dealt with "culture shock"?

I haven't really had culture shock, more just the uncomfortableness and frustrations that come with moving to a new place.

What about your experience thus far has been the most...surprising?

How many amazing hiking places there are in Kenya! I found an awesome group that goes hiking on the weekends and takes public transportation. It has been a great experience.

What about your experience thus far has been the most...challenging?

Not enjoying the line of work I am doing and working in a very traditional organization. It has made me reconsider my whole career trajectory and is something I struggle with on the daily.

What are the top 3 things you miss the most from your home country or the U.S.?

My car and the freedom that comes with it, no traffic and little pollution, not getting unwanted attention because I am a woman

What are the top 3 things about life in your host country that beat out life in your home country or the U.S.?

The weather, the price of food and rent

How is your stipend being paid?

Monthly but erratically, sometimes I get paid on the 26th of the month, other times on the 15th. This makes it really hard to plan out a stipend for a whole month. It is paid to a U.S. account.

How are you receiving your stipend funds?

ACH

Did you raise funds to cover part of your fellowship expenses?

no

Please list any additional one-time or infrequent expenses not included in your monthly budget below.

Monthly Budget

Rent	Utilities	Furnishings	Phone	Home Security	Internet
\$350.00	\$0.00	\$0.00	\$0.00	\$0.00	\$0.00
Transportation	Fitness	Entertainment	Groceries	House Cleaning	Eating Out
\$160.00	\$100.00	\$100.00	\$120.00	\$0.00	\$100.00
Medications	Additional Health Insurance	Travel	Laundry	Other	Total Monthly Budget (Minus Entertainment & Travel)
\$0.00	\$0.00	\$400.00	\$0.00	\$0.00	830.00
Specify "Other"					

Final Thoughts

PiAf's orientation was sufficient in preparing me to transition into my fellowship.

Agree

Please briefly explain your response about Orientation.

It was a lot of information crammed into 5 days with little follow-up afterwards. I'm not sure how the lessons could continue after and into the start of the fellowship but it felt really rushed and then ended abruptly.

Is there anything in particular that PiAf could cover at orientation that would have better prepared you for your fellowship post? Please specify.

There needs to be more of a conversation surrounding visas and how to navigate that.

As we plan the upcoming PiAf Retreat, we hope to incorporate some Fellow suggestions into our programming. What are some topics or sessions you would like to see at the Retreat? (We appreciate your feedback however, we may not be able to accommodate all suggestions or requests this year.)

1. Earlier notification of when and where the retreat will be: it is really difficult to plan anything without knowing!
2. Transparency surrounding stipends: there needs to be more conversation and transparency between fellows on stipends. I especially see this in the Nairobi fellow cohort. We are getting paid drastically different stipends even though we live in the same city and had no idea until we started discussing it on the ground.